

STAGE THIRTEEN • TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 30 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Thirteen • Teamwork & Collaboration

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Thirteen, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Thirteen covers thirty FIRSTS across three sections: Team Foundations, Working Together in Practice, and Navigating Difficulty & Closing Out. Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt.

This stage is the genuine peer-level counterpart to Stage Twelve's leadership focus — it's about being a strong team member, not necessarily the person leading the team. Several FIRSTS here explicitly reference that distinction; keep it visible for participants who may be more used to thinking about teamwork purely from a leadership angle.

Wherever possible, participants should apply this stage's exercises to a real, current team project rather than a hypothetical one — the content is significantly more useful grounded in something genuinely ongoing.

SESSION 1

Team Foundations

Covers *FIRSTS* Q1–Q10

FIRST Q1

Team Formation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants confirm genuine shared-objective alignment before forming or joining a real team.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Teams formed with deliberate intention around a genuinely shared objective function far better than ones assembled by default or convenience.
- Proximity or existing friendship is a starting point, not the same thing as genuine alignment on what the team is actually trying to achieve.
- This is the foundation for the entire section; everything through Q10 assumes at least reasonable alignment at formation.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Forming a team purely based on convenience or existing friendship, without checking for genuine alignment around the actual shared objective.
 - Assuming a team will naturally align later, without confirming it upfront.
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SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q2

Team Goal Alignment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants explicitly confirm every team member shares the same understanding of the team's actual objective.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A team without confirmed alignment risks members quietly pursuing different interpretations of success — a costly, avoidable problem.
- A shared kickoff meeting doesn't guarantee shared interpretation of what was actually discussed.
- This directly extends Q1: formation gets you in the room, alignment confirms everyone's actually pointed the same direction.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming a larger team naturally shares the same understanding just because everyone attended the same kickoff meeting.
- Treating alignment as a one-time check rather than something worth periodically reconfirming.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q3

Team Roles Defined

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map every major team responsibility with clear, confirmed ownership, not just their own role.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unclear roles produce either duplicated effort or genuine gaps where work falls through the cracks.
- Knowing your own role isn't enough — the value comes from everyone knowing who owns everything.
- This is a fast, high-leverage exercise; most teams skip it and pay for it later.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Defining only your own role clearly while leaving the rest of the team's responsibilities vague or assumed.
- Assuming roles will naturally clarify themselves as the work progresses.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q4

Team Working Agreement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft explicit working norms covering communication, deadlines, meetings, and accountability.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Mismatched expectations — instant response versus days of delay — create avoidable friction when norms are never made explicit.
- This should be a genuine, written agreement, not an assumed shared understanding.
- Establishing this early protects the team from friction that's far harder to resolve mid-project.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming working norms are obvious or will naturally align, without ever explicitly discussing and agreeing on them.
- Treating a working agreement as unnecessary bureaucracy rather than genuine friction prevention.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q5

Collaborative Planning Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a real project plan together as a full team, not as one person's draft for approval.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Plans built collectively tend to be both more realistic and more genuinely owned by everyone than plans handed down from a single planner.
- A plan presented for approval, rather than built together, misses genuine input that could catch real issues early.
- This is a natural extension of Q3's roles and Q4's working agreement into actual project structure.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Having one person build the plan alone and simply present it for approval, missing the genuine input and buy-in a real collaborative process provides.
- Treating a collaborative planning session as a formality rather than genuine joint work.

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST Q6

Collaborative Brainstorming Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants run a structured, judgment-free brainstorm with their full team.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Structured group brainstorming, done well, produces both more ideas and better ones than individual brainstorming or unstructured discussion.
- Judging ideas during generation suppresses the range of ideas the group actually produces — separate generation from evaluation.
- This is a genuinely learnable skill, not just “getting people in a room together.”

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Judging or discussing ideas during the generation phase, which suppresses the range of ideas produced by the group.
- Assuming unstructured discussion is just as effective as a genuinely structured brainstorm.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q7

Shared Decision-Making Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants make a real team decision with genuine, confirmed buy-in, not just an absence of vocal objection.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuinely shared decisions, with real input and confirmed buy-in, tend to produce both better decisions and stronger commitment to executing them.

- Silence is not the same as agreement — buy-in has to be actively confirmed, especially from quieter team members.
- This is distinct from Q23's consensus exercise later in the stage; this is about the process of making one significant decision well.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Mistaking silence for genuine agreement, rather than actively confirming real buy-in from quieter team members.
- Rushing to a decision without genuinely hearing from everyone first.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q8

Team Task Delegation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants distribute team tasks based on genuine fit and fairness, not just who spoke up first.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Fair, strategic delegation across an entire team prevents both uneven workload and mismatched task-to-skill fit at scale.
- Whoever speaks up first in a meeting isn't necessarily the best fit for a given task — deliberate distribution beats default assignment.
- This scales Q3's role clarity into actual, ongoing task assignment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Distributing tasks based purely on who spoke up first in a meeting, rather than genuine fit and fairness across the whole team.
- Assuming an even task count means an even, fair workload.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q9

Team Accountability System

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a shared, visible tracking system the whole team, not just a designated leader, actually uses.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a genuine, visible system, commitments quietly slip and no one has clear visibility into what's actually on track.
- Accountability tracking shouldn't be seen as solely a leader's job — a genuinely shared, peer-visible system works better.
- This directly extends Q4's working agreement into an actual operational tool.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming accountability tracking is only a leader's responsibility, missing the value of a genuinely shared, peer-visible system.
 - Setting up a system once and never actually reviewing or using it consistently.
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SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST Q10

Team Check-In

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants establish a lightweight, recurring check-in cadence that actually catches obstacles early.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular, lightweight check-ins catch small obstacles before they become significant blockers, without the overhead of a full formal meeting.
- Treating every check-in as a full meeting adds unnecessary friction and discourages the team from actually doing it consistently.
- This closes the section by turning everything from Q1 through Q9 into an ongoing, sustainable rhythm.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating every check-in as a full formal meeting, which adds unnecessary overhead and discourages the team from actually doing it consistently.
 - Skipping check-ins when things feel like they're going fine, missing early signals of a real problem forming.
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SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 2

Working Together in Practice

Covers *FIRSTS* Q11–Q20

FIRST Q11

Collaborative Problem-Solving Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants solve a real shared problem, ensuring every team member's perspective is genuinely heard before converging.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Problems tackled collectively often surface better solutions than any individual would reach alone, but only when genuinely structured to draw out everyone's thinking.
- The most vocal team member's solution can dominate if the process doesn't deliberately create space for quieter members first.
- This scales Q7's shared decision-making into a genuinely structured problem-solving process.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting the most vocal team member's solution dominate without genuinely hearing quieter members' perspectives first.
 - Converging on a solution too quickly, before the full range of perspectives is actually on the table.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q12

Team Documentation System

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up shared documentation with clear conventions for who updates what, and confirm more than one person actually uses it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Documentation maintained by only one person tends to go stale; genuinely shared, team-maintained documentation stays current.
- Setting up shared documentation isn't enough if only one person actually keeps it updated — that recreates the exact problem it's meant to solve.
- This directly supports Q9's accountability system by giving the team a shared source of truth.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting up shared documentation but having only one person actually maintain it, which recreates the same single-point-of-failure problem shared documentation is meant to solve.
- Assuming documentation, once created, doesn't need ongoing attention.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q13

Collaborative Digital Workspace

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants confirm whether the full team, not just some members, is genuinely using their shared digital workspace.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A digital workspace only creates value once the full team genuinely adopts it together; partial adoption recreates real coordination problems.
- A tool only some people use creates confusion about where current, real information actually lives.
- This is a genuine adoption check, not just a tool-selection exercise.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting up a shared workspace that only some team members actually use, which creates confusion about where real, current information lives.
- Assuming adoption once means adoption forever, without checking in periodically.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q14

Cross-Functional Team Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one way to translate their communication for a different function's priorities.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Cross-functional teams require genuine translation between different disciplines' vocabularies and priorities, a skill built through sustained experience.
- Assuming your own function's vocabulary translates directly to a different discipline, without adjustment, is a common, easily fixed mistake.
- This is the first of three FIRSTS (Q14–Q16) about collaborating across genuine difference.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming your own function's vocabulary and priorities translate directly to a genuinely different discipline without adjustment.
- Treating cross-functional friction as a personality issue rather than a genuine translation gap.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q15

Multicultural Team Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants notice one genuine communication preference difference on a multicultural team and adjust their own approach.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Multicultural teams bring genuine strengths through diverse perspectives, but require real awareness of different communication norms.
- Assuming your own default communication style is culturally neutral is a common, invisible mistake worth naming directly.
- This connects to the Cross-Cultural Communication work from Stage Six, applied specifically to team collaboration.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming your own default communication style is culturally neutral, missing genuine differences in how teammates from other backgrounds prefer to communicate.
- Treating cultural differences in communication style as a problem to fix rather than a genuine strength to understand.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q16

Remote Team Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants establish one explicit norm for handling communication with real emotional or interpretive stakes on a remote team.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Remote collaboration requires more deliberate communication since informal cues and hallway conversations are largely lost.
- Assuming remote communication carries the same context as in-person misses the extra deliberate effort genuine remote collaboration requires.
- This closes the Q14-Q16 arc on collaborating across genuine difference — function, culture, and now physical distance.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming remote communication carries the same context as in-person, missing the extra deliberate effort genuine remote collaboration requires.
- Defaulting to text-only communication for anything with real emotional or interpretive stakes.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q17

Asynchronous Collaboration Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a genuinely self-contained team update assuming no real-time follow-up is possible.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Asynchronous work requires genuinely different habits than real-time collaboration, particularly clear, self-contained communication.
- Writing updates that assume real-time clarifying questions will be possible breaks down completely when team members are never online together.
- This directly complements Q16's remote work focus with a specifically async-specific skill.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing updates that assume real-time clarifying questions will be possible, which breaks down when team members are never online at the same time.
 - Treating async communication as just slower real-time communication, rather than a genuinely distinct format.
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SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q18

Team Handoff

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants document a clear handoff covering status, context, and open questions for a real work transfer.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Poorly executed handoffs are a common source of lost work and repeated mistakes; a clear, deliberate process protects genuine continuity.
- A brief verbal summary misses important context that only becomes apparent once someone else actually tries to pick up the work.
- This is a high-leverage, genuinely practical skill applicable well beyond this specific stage.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Handing off work with only a brief verbal summary, missing the important context that only becomes apparent once someone else tries to actually pick up the work.
 - Assuming the receiving person will simply ask if something's unclear, rather than proactively documenting it.
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SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q19

Peer Review Within a Team

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give specific, actionable feedback on a teammate's work at a real checkpoint, not just at the end.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular peer review catches issues earlier and builds a shared standard of quality, rather than relying solely on a single leader's review.
- Relying solely on a leader's review misses the broader quality-catching and skill-building value of genuine peer-to-peer review.

- This directly extends the Peer Review Participation FIRST from Stage Eight into an embedded team practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying solely on a single leader's review, missing the broader quality-catching and skill-building value of genuine peer-to-peer review.
- Giving feedback so vague it provides no genuine, actionable guidance.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q20

Team Feedback Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants propose a regular, proactive team feedback session, not tied to any specific problem.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular, structured feedback sessions build a genuine culture of continuous improvement, rather than feedback only happening reactively.
- Waiting until something goes wrong to give feedback misses the proactive, culture-building value of regular practice.
- This closes the section by turning Q19's individual peer review into a full, structured team practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only holding feedback sessions reactively after something has already gone wrong, missing the proactive, culture-building value of regular practice.
- Assuming feedback sessions require a designated leader to run rather than something the whole team can own together.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 3

Navigating Difficulty & Closing Out

Covers *FIRSTS* Q21–Q30

FIRST Q21

Team Conflict Resolution

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a genuine tension between teammates and consider offering to help mediate, even without formal authority.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Conflict resolution isn't only a designated leader's job; any team member genuinely capable of helping contributes real value to the team's effectiveness.
- Assuming conflict resolution belongs solely to a leader misses the value any team member can bring as a peer mediator.
- This is the peer-level counterpart to the leader-driven conflict handling covered in Stage Twelve.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming conflict resolution is only a designated leader's responsibility, missing the value any team member can bring as a peer mediator.
 - Avoiding involvement in a team conflict out of a belief that it's not genuinely your place to help.
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SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q22

Difficult Teammate Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one specific behavior, not the whole person, causing friction with a difficult teammate, and address it professionally.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Not every teammate will be someone you'd naturally choose to work with; remaining professional and productive despite genuine friction is a distinct, valuable skill.
- Letting personal frustration visibly affect collaboration quality damages the work and the relationship both.
- Focusing on a specific behavior, not a character judgment, is what makes this genuinely addressable.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting personal frustration with a difficult teammate visibly affect the quality or professionalism of your actual collaboration.
- Framing the issue as “this person is difficult” rather than a specific, addressable behavior.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q23

Team Consensus Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants work explicitly toward full team consensus rather than settling for a majority vote.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine consensus produces stronger follow-through than a majority-vote decision with a dissenting minority left unaddressed.
- A majority vote is not the same thing as consensus — unaddressed minority concerns can still undermine execution later.
- This is a genuinely harder, more time-consuming process than a vote, and worth it for decisions where real buy-in matters.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Mistaking a majority vote for genuine consensus, when a dissenting minority's unaddressed concerns can still undermine execution.
- Assuming consensus requires unanimous enthusiasm rather than genuine, considered agreement.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q24

Team Compromise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants find a genuine, mutually supportable compromise where full consensus isn't realistic.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Not every disagreement can reach full consensus; a genuine, workable compromise keeps the team moving forward without forcing a false agreement.
- Pressuring a dissenting side to simply go along is not the same as a genuine compromise both sides can actually support.
- This directly complements Q23 for the situations where consensus genuinely isn't achievable.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Forcing a false consensus by pressuring the dissenting side to simply go along, rather than finding a genuine compromise both sides can authentically support.
- Treating compromise as a lesser outcome rather than a genuinely valid resolution in its own right.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q25

Team Recognition Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants recognize a teammate's specific contribution in the moment it happens, not just retrospectively.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine contributions often go unnoticed without deliberate acknowledgment; consistent, timely recognition builds team morale.
- Saving all recognition for a project's formal conclusion misses the ongoing morale benefit of in-the-moment acknowledgment.
- This is a small, low-cost habit with disproportionately real relational value, echoing Stage Ten's appreciation practices.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Saving all recognition for a project's formal conclusion, missing the ongoing morale benefit of timely, in-the-moment acknowledgment.
- Offering only generic praise rather than specific, genuine recognition.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q26

Team Celebration

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants plan something specific to mark their team's next real milestone.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Celebrating milestones together builds shared positive memory and reinforces a sense of collective accomplishment.
- Moving immediately to the next task without pausing to genuinely mark an accomplishment is a common, easily fixed oversight.
- This doesn't need to be elaborate; genuine intentionality matters more than scale.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Moving immediately to the next task without pausing to genuinely mark a real accomplishment together.
- Assuming celebration only counts if it's elaborate or expensive.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST Q27

Team Retrospective

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants hold a structured retrospective covering what worked, what didn't, and what to change.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A genuine retrospective, honestly examining both successes and failures, turns a team's experience into real, actionable learning.

- A retrospective that only covers what went well avoids the harder, more valuable honest examination of what genuinely failed.
- This sets up Q29's lesson-learned document by generating the raw material for it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Conducting a retrospective that only covers what went well, avoiding the harder, more valuable honest examination of what genuinely failed.
- Treating a retrospective as a blame session rather than genuine, forward-looking learning.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q28

Team Performance Assessment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants, as a full team, compare actual outcomes against their original objective.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A team's own honest, collective self-assessment builds shared ownership of both successes and shortfalls.
- Leaving performance assessment solely to a designated leader misses the more complete picture a genuinely collective assessment provides.
- This is the peer-level, collective counterpart to the leader-driven Team Performance Review from Stage Twelve.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving performance assessment solely to a designated leader, missing the more complete picture a genuinely collective assessment provides.
- Assessing performance based on effort alone rather than genuine outcomes against the original objective.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST Q29

Team Lesson-Learned Document

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants turn their most recent retrospective into a specific, actionable lesson-learned document.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Lessons that only live in memory tend to fade and get relearned the hard way; a genuine written document preserves them for real future use.
- Vague lessons (“communicate better”) provide no genuine, actionable guidance for a future team to actually apply.
- This directly extends Q27's retrospective into a lasting, referenceable artifact.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing lessons so vague (“communicate better”) that they provide no genuine, actionable guidance for a future team to actually apply.
 - Writing the document and never actually referencing it on a future project.
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SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST Q30

High-Performing Team Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately combine at least three practices from this stage on a real team project, and reflect on the compounding effect.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- High-performing teams don't happen by accident; they result from deliberately combining practices like the ones built throughout this stage.
- Applying these practices in isolation across different projects misses the genuine compounding effect of combining them deliberately.
- This closes the entire stage by asking participants to integrate everything, not just recall it individually.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Applying these practices in isolation across different projects without ever deliberately combining them together on a single team to see the genuine compounding effect.
 - Assuming high performance is about individual talent rather than deliberately combined team practices.
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SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*